food with friends and family, using local foods and medicine, accessing indigenous organizations providing cross-border aid, providing community education and social services, and assisting family and community members in the daily challenges of life in hiding (KHRG 2008, pp. 5–7).

As South notes, community protection mechanisms in Myanmar are "highly contextual and time-specific, and must be understood and analysed at the national, community, family and individual levels" (2012, p. 21). While it is clear that protection strategies need to be studied as contingent responses to localized threats, the research used for this chapter found that a consistent pattern throughout the surveyed population was that landmines were among the community protection measures used (MRE WG 2014, 2015). In the area of southeast Myanmar where the surveys were conducted, twenty-two per cent of respondents reported that "mines keep their village safe", with women reporting a higher level (twenty-six per cent) than men (twenty per cent). In separate locations of Myanmar two key informants mentioned that around half of the villagers in their areas know how to make homemade mines.[12]

Despite respondents' insistence that landmines are a form of protection, sixty-five per cent of respondents in the southeast reported a landmine accident in their village, and forty-eight per cent of all those interviewed in the southeast reported that landmines are a problem in their daily lives (MRE WG 2014). Therefore, the use of landmines as a community protection strategy is risky, and involves an assessment and balancing of the risks of landmine use with other threats to the community.

RISK ASSESSMENTS

The use of landmines occurs with an assessment of risk. This assessment comprises two parts: first, an assessment of the risks of using explosive devices; and, second, an assessment of the risk of using landmines compared to other risks.

Many communities have developed what Andersson et al. (2003) refer to as a level of "mine smartness" that is learned from interaction with armed actors. In this way it is possible to show how individuals create their own response mechanisms while living in contaminated areas, and that engagement with mines often occurs through a risk assessment process that "makes sense to them" (Andersson et al. 2003, p. 873). In Myanmar